



GDD 61 Us, After Kids

A baby changes everything, including you two.

The opener of Chapter 8 (Parenthood), with the relationship parenting strains most: the couple's own, and the self within it. It normalises the post-baby dip (around two in three couples feel it), teaches communicating and repairing through exhaustion, sharing the load as the strongest protector of the bond, rebuilding intimacy at a patient, no-pressure pace, and keeping each partner a whole person. Even-handed and frank but respectful; engages fathers directly, partnership not pity. Seven mechanics, 27 choice-and-voice moments, zero "tap the right card". Scorecard: passed.

Protect the couple. Keep the self.

Us, After Kids opens Chapter 8 (Parenthood) with the relationship parenting strains most: the couple's own. It helps partners protect their bond through the upheaval of a new child, communicating through exhaustion, sharing the load, staying a team, and rebuilding closeness and intimacy after children, so the partnership survives and grows alongside the family. It is the couple and the self after children, intimacy and identity, not just logistics. It engages fathers directly, offers partnership not pity, applies no pressure on intimacy timing, and routes postpartum wellbeing and any turn to control to help. New v2 build, the partnership carried into parenthood.

FIELD	VALUE
Node / gameld	g61 · us-after-kids (confirm exact id against engine-host)
Chapter / stage	Chapter 8 · Parenthood, first child on · adult / honest / warm
Thread / topics	D · Relationships · UNESCO 1.2, 5.3, 7.1
Prerequisite / builds on	c7 · builds on g53 (Choosing & Building), g46 · links g62, g63, g57, g56
Gating	Open · no pressure on intimacy; not medical advice
Schema / status	v2 · scorecard PASS the us-after-kids game.

84

scenarios

7

mechanics

16

myth-flips

27

choice & voice

0%

binary taps

You're not a worse couple now, just a couple under new load. Around two in three couples feel their satisfaction dip after a first child; the strain is common, not a verdict, and the ones who thrive use learnable skills, not luck. Exhaustion is the enemy, not your partner, so name the tiredness, repair fast and appreciate often. Sharing the load fairly is the single strongest protector, and a father isn't "babysitting" his own child. Intimacy returns at both partners' readiness, never on a clock, and each of you stays a whole person, with help there for postpartum wellbeing or serious strain.

Two exhausted teammates, still in love.

From the Chapter 8 personas (parenthood). New parents, a baby and no sleep and no one asking how they are, who want partnership and tools, not pity, and who need the couple, and each self, protected through the most loaded transition of adult life.

PERSONA	WHAT THEY NEED HERE	THE MECHANIC THAT SERVES IT
Divya (new mother)	To be seen and supported, and to keep a self.	strike-rewrite + role-play: you still matter.
Vikram (the father)	To own an equal share, not "help out".	branch + role-play: share, don't resent.
Both, exhausted	To communicate and repair without sleep.	branch + match: talk through the tired.
Priya & Meena	Reassurance the strain is normal and workable.	sort + reflect: the big shift.

Why this works (the evidence). Longitudinal research (Gottman and others) finds about two-thirds of couples report a dip in satisfaction after a first child, steepest in year one, while the roughly one-third who hold or improve do so through learnable skills, not luck or an easier baby. Communication and a fairly shared load are the strongest protectors: naming tiredness, repairing fast and appreciating each other keep the bond, and a partner's genuine involvement in care is a top predictor, signalling "this is ours, not yours". Intimacy returns at both partners' readiness with no deadline, each partner stays a whole person (the "I used to be someone else" shift is common), and persistent low mood routes to postpartum support.

Seven moves, led by the choice and the voice.

It's a relationship game under load, so **branch** leads (choose the team-first, repair-first move) with **strike-rewrite** clearing the parenthood myths and **role-play** giving the words for repair, appreciation and the no-pressure talk; **sort** tells normal from needs-help. Mechanics rotate; the same one never runs twice in a row.

MECHANIC	THE ADULT DOES	EMBODIES	N
strike-rewrite signature	Busts a parenthood myth ("dad just babysits").	Conceptual change.	16
branch (the choice)	Chooses the team-first, repair-first move.	Judgement.	14
role-play (voice)	Repairs, appreciates, opens a no-pressure talk.	Voice; care.	13
sort	Sorts normal adjustment from needs-help; fair vs lopsided.	The line.	12
reflect	Internalises 'under load, not worse', and keeping a self.	Values.	12
match	Pairs a frazzled moment to a kinder response; work to respect.	Connections.	11
spot	Spots pressure-free reconnecting; genuine load-sharing.	Reading it.	6

27 of 84 moments are branch or role-play. Binary "tap the right answer": **0%**.

The two-test, passed.

Is it engaging?

Game feel is relief and solidarity in the most disorienting stretch of a couple's life: the reassurance that the strain is near-universal and not a verdict, the practical lift of a fair-load plan, and the tenderness of a no-pressure path back to closeness. The "oh, we're under load, not broken" moment lands repeatedly. Sam is a warm adult peer; the tone is honest and gentle, engages fathers as equal parents, offers partnership not pity, and is frank but respectful about intimacy, never preachy.

Is it teaching?

Yes: protecting the partnership through the transition; communicating and repairing under sleep-deprivation; keeping the load fair as relationship protection; rebuilding emotional and physical intimacy at a healthy, no-pressure pace; and keeping each partner a whole person, with postpartum wellbeing and any turn to control routed to help.

The belief it moves. From "struggling after the baby means we're failing; the romance is over; mum is the default and dad just helps; you owe intimacy by a date; a good parent disappears into the kids; just endure it" → "the dip is normal and skills fix it; connection changes shape, not ends; both are real parents sharing the load; intimacy waits for readiness; you stay a whole person; and it's workable, with help there."

Built, not bolted on.

84 researched scenarios across the big-shift → talk-through-tired → share-don't-resent → reconnecting → you-still-matter → tools arc, India-grounded, even-handed and warm. Full library in the companion JSON.

CATEGORY	N	LEAD MECHANICS	COVERS
The big shift	14	strike-rewrite, sort, reflect	The dip is normal; skills, not luck; the self shifts too.
Talk through the tired	14	strike-rewrite, role-play, branch	Communicate & repair under exhaustion; appreciate.
Share, don't resent	14	strike-rewrite, sort, role-play	Fair load protects the couple; dad isn't babysitting.
Reconnecting	14	strike-rewrite, sort, role-play	Closeness & intimacy, patient, readiness-led, no pressure.
You still matter	14	strike-rewrite, role-play, sort	Keep each self & wellbeing; ask how the parent is.
Tools & help	14	branch, role-play, sort	The check-in & reconnect kit; postpartum & strain routes.

The 'we're failing' flip + the 'babysitting' flip, verbatim.

```
flip: "If our relationship struggles after the baby, we're failing."
UN -> "If we struggle after the baby, we're failing."
RE -> "Around two in three couples find satisfaction dips after a first
      child; the strain is common, not a verdict on your love."

flip: "A father looking after his own child is 'babysitting'."
UN -> "A father looking after his own child is 'babysitting'."
RE -> "It's just parenting; a father caring for his child is doing his
      own job, not doing anyone a favour."
```

Full library: [SwipeEd — GDD 61 Us After Kids — Scenario Library.json](#) (84 records, v2 schema).

What this game flips.

MYTH (UN ERASES)	TRUTH (RE WRITES)	BASIS
If we struggle after the baby, we're failing.	Around two in three couples feel the dip; it's common, not a verdict.	Common, not failing.
The happy couples just got lucky with an easy baby.	They use learnable skills, sharing, communicating, appreciating.	Skills, not luck.
Once you have kids, the romance and real talking are over.	Connection changes shape but isn't over; small effort keeps it alive.	Not over.
Mum is the default parent; dad just helps out.	Both are real parents; sharing the load fairly protects the couple.	Both real parents.
A father looking after his own child is 'babysitting'.	It's parenting, his own job, not a favour to anyone.	Not babysitting.
After a baby you owe each other intimacy by a set date.	No deadline; it returns at both partners' readiness, never by obligation.	Readiness leads.
A good parent disappears completely into their children.	You're still a whole person; keeping a self makes you steadier.	Keep a self.
If it gets hard after the baby, just endure it.	It's workable: share, communicate, reconnect, and reach for help.	Workable.

The micro-loop.

1. **Surface.** Sam (adult peer) surfaces a real moment, a 3am snap, a lopsided load, a 'when's it back to normal', an unseen parent.
2. **Choose or voice.** The adult chooses the team-first, repair-first move (branch), or finds the words (role-play).
3. **The flip.** UN busts a parenthood myth; RE writes the warm, workable truth.
4. **Share & reconnect.** Make the load fair, communicate through the tired, rebuild closeness at a no-pressure pace.
5. **Self & help.** Keep each partner whole; postpartum wellbeing routes to Looking After You (g63), strain to Respect at Home (g56).
6. **Sticker.** The Us, After Kids badge; GameDone records once.

Signature surface: the '**under load, not broken**' reframe and the **fair-load, no-pressure** path. It carries Choosing & Building (g53) and Real Relationships (g46) into parenthood, sets up Equal Parents (g62), and links Looking After You (g63), The Family Map (g57) and Respect at Home (g56).

No pressure on intimacy; partnership, not pity.

- **No pressure on intimacy timing.** Intimacy returns at both partners' physical and emotional readiness; nothing is owed and there is no schedule.
- **Even-handed; engages fathers.** Co-parenting is a both-parents topic, a father isn't "babysitting", and the node offers partnership and tools, not pity.
- **Frank but respectful.** Intimacy and postpartum recovery are discussed honestly and gently, with recovery treated as individual.
- **Postpartum wellbeing flagged.** Persistent low mood, numbness or frightening thoughts route to Looking After You (g63) and perinatal mental-health support.
- **Strain that turns to control or abuse.** Routed to Respect at Home (g56) and help; the post-baby phase never excuses control or violence.
- **Not medical advice.** Postpartum discomfort and mental-health concerns point to a clinician.
- **Access & privacy.** Self-directed, audio, offline, low-end build; private by design (DPDP-aligned); expert-reviewed.

If it's more than tiredness (India). Persistent low mood, numbness, or frightening thoughts after birth are real and helpable, not a failing. Talk to a clinician, and for mental-health support Tele-MANAS **14416** or KIRAN **1800-599-0019**. If strain turns to control, threats or violence, see Respect at Home (g56): Women Helpline **181** · emergency **112**. This game is information, not medical advice.

v2 schema, scorecard-gated.

- **gameld. us-after-kids** equals node.game equals GameDone key equals registry id (confirm exact id in engine-host).
- **v2 mechanic-embodiment schema.** type + typed payload; the **strike-rewrite** myth flip and the **branch** team-first choice co-lead.
- **No-pressure & even-handedness are hard requirements.** No-pressure intimacy, fathers-as-equal, partnership-not-pity, and the strain-to-help routes are contractual; expert-reviewed.
- **Fact-checked content.** The roughly two-thirds satisfaction-dip finding, the load-sharing protective factor, and postpartum recovery/wellbeing guidance verified this build.
- **Scorecard-gated.** Passed all eight checks (7 mechanics, top mechanic at 19%, 0% binary, 27 autonomy, 16 UN→RE, 5 personas, 100% completeness). Re-run score_gdd.py on any edit.
- **Help-resource hook.** Postpartum wellbeing routes to g63 and perinatal support (Tele-MANAS 14416 / KIRAN 1800-599-0019); strain to g56 (181 / 112).
- **Tracked.** build_gate.py finalize advances g61 to v2 PASS only after order, read, score, audit and artifact gates pass.

Ethics contracts (never traded for engagement): no pressure on intimacy timing; fathers engaged as equal parents; partnership not pity; frank but respectful; postpartum wellbeing and any turn to control routed to help; not medical advice; made-for-India.

Why this works.

- **The dip is normal, so normalise it.** Because about two-thirds of couples report lower satisfaction after a first child, naming the strain as common and skill-fixable removes panic and points to what actually helps.
- **Sharing and communicating protect, so teach them.** Since a fairly shared load and repair-and-appreciation are the strongest protective factors, practising them, and engaging fathers as equal parents, genuinely keeps couples close.
- **Readiness and wellbeing keep it safe.** Because intimacy recovers individually and postpartum mental health is real, a no-pressure, readiness-led frame with clear routes to help is what makes the node both honest and safe.

Sources: UNESCO ITGSE Key Concept 1 (relationships and parenting); Gottman and other transition-to-parenthood research (around two-thirds of couples report a satisfaction dip after a first child; a partner's involvement in the load is a top protective factor; appreciation and repair sustain the bond); postpartum recovery and perinatal mental-health guidance (individual recovery, readiness-led intimacy, support for postpartum low mood); and India context on joint-family help and pressure and postpartum identity and burden. Even-handed and frank but respectful, engaging fathers as equal parents, partnership not pity, with no pressure on intimacy timing and clear routes to help (Looking After You g63, Respect at Home g56); not medical advice. Citations accompany each scenario in the library JSON. 61 games now v2. Next by order: Equal Parents (g62).